

Why are AI data centers bad for environment?

Posted by u/onekeanui • 0 points • 7 comments

I saw a video briefly about an empty town due to AI data centers but it had to information.

Comments

u/Delehal • 2 points • 2026-02-27 18:09 UTC

They use a lot of water and electricity. The electricity is the bigger problem, especially if they are powered by wasteful generators such as old coal plants.

The water isn't as big of a problem as a lot of people seem to think. The bigger issue is in a lot of countries, including the US, data centers are being planned and approved at a local city/town level when they can impact a much larger area than that. That can cause unexpected impact on local utilities if things aren't planned well, which is hard to do without more centralized planning at county or state level.

u/bangbangracer • 3 points • 2026-02-27 16:27 UTC

They consume a lot of resources, often more than the infrastructure can handle, and they create noise.

Data centers are sold to areas on the idea that they will bring in jobs. They don't bring in that many jobs, especially once construction is done, and locals experience skyrocketing power and water bills. It's also very common for water pressure to disappear in the area because of the water demands of the data center. The infrastructure needs massive upgrades and can't support the new demand.

This question gets answered daily here, and nearly hourly.

u/tall_specimen_69 • 3 points • 2026-02-27 16:23 UTC

Too much noise, takes a lot of water and needs to dump that water into streams too, a lot of electricity consumption. And not a lot of jobs are generated compared to any other large industry.

u/zenfaust • 2 points • 2026-02-27 19:06 UTC

If you consider how most are being used to further the capabilities of AI, it's not just creating less jobs, it's actively deleting them from damn near every white collar profession.

u/GESNodeon • 3 points • 2026-02-27 16:26 UTC

Many of them do not need to dump the water, thankfully. The better ones can reuse the same water.

u/GESNodeon • 7 points • 2026-02-27 16:22 UTC

They use a lot of electricity and water. They create a lot of noise.

A data center will often cause the costs for utilities to increase and the noise is very annoying to people/wildlife.

u/Antique_Cod_1686 • 1 points • 2026-02-28 04:11 UTC

Are they still bad for the environment if they use closed-loop water cooling and operate in a country that generates 80-100% renewable energy?